Chapter 1: Convocation Day

It was finally my turn to cross the stage. Ten years of work, and far more money than I would rather admit, put into this moment. Sure, I've done it twice already, but this time means I'm done with school – a thought that still irks me to this day. As you'll come to know, I'm a gigantic nerd with a lot of weird… let's just say… *quirks*. Education is just one of those: for some reason, I just can't get enough, and the thought of being done with school made me feel uneasy. It's hard to think that a few months earlier, I was in a lecture theatre, filled with nervousness, preparing to defend my doctoral thesis in front of the committee. *What if I screw up? What if they don't think my work deserves a doctorate? Were the past years of work I've put into this worth it?* The *What if...* questions were all I could think about. Within the first ten minutes or so, the nerves seemed to subside for the most part, and all was going well. I finished my presentation, and the committee started asking questions about my research. I was able to quickly answer most of them from my preparations, but there were a few that I had to think about before formulating an answer. It was nearing the end of my time slot, and the committee chair asked everyone on the panel if they had any final questions before they moved to deciding my fate. All but one panel member had no questions, and to answer the one who did, I launched into another one of the overly explained presentations I've come to be known for. After the panel was satisfied, the chair said, "The panel will now move to deliberations. You will be notified when our decision is ready." I thanked the panel members and gracefully left the room. Immediately after the door closed behind me, my body shook. The nerves had returned, and they seemed ten times worse.

I wanted to talk to someone, but there was nobody I could talk to. Usually when I felt like this, I'd talk to my supervisor, Dr. Browne, or my best friend Noah Harper. Dr. Browne was in the room figuring out whether I would achieve the pinnacle of academia, and Noah was at a hockey training camp. Everyone else attending my defense were interested community members, and I didn't know anyone. This was the moment that could make or break the last ten years of my life, and despite my best efforts, I was all alone. As every second passed, the thoughts I had before rushed back into my head. When the monitor came out into the corridor to tell me the committee finished their deliberations, the nerves intensified. Mostly because they'd only been deliberating for an hour by that point, which could either mean I messed up so badly that I'd have to completely rewrite my entire thesis, or my work was so good they had no concerns about it – at least, that's what I heard. Having the worst-case scenario in mind, as I usually do, I nervously entered the room and tried my best to maintain my composure while I walked to the front. "Doctor Thorpe," the chairperson of the committee started, with a smile on her face that washed all my nervousness away, "your work is genuinely interesting, and very worthy of promotion. We have unanimously decided that your defense was successful and to accept your thesis, pending a few minor revisions that your supervisor will inform you of in the coming days."

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Wow. Dr. Thorpe. It has a good ring to it, doesn't it? Dr. Cameron Thorpe. Dr. *Cam* Thorpe? I prefer Cameron – I always have. I don't really know why – it just never felt right. It never felt like *me*. "Thank you all for your confidence. I appreciate your time, and I look forward to publishing more work in the future," I said, trying to keep from exploding with excitement. I needed to be professional; these people have been my mentors for years, after all. I always maintained some level of professionalism with them. "We look forward to reading your future work. Good luck, Dr. Thorpe, and congratulations from us all - you deserve it," I heard as I exited the room.

You might think the first thing I would do would be to call my parents. That's what most people would do, but for some reason, I called Noah instead. I've always felt closer to him than to my parents, so calling him felt more natural to me. "I did it – the panel accepted my thesis! I'm going to be a doctor!" I told him the second he answered, almost screaming. I was shaking uncontrollably with excitement and trying to hold back the ocean of tears that had been building up since I heard those first few words from the committee chair.
"Nice man, I knew you would crush it! You put so much work into it too, so to nail your defense the first time – it must feel good. I know you were worried about that. It sucks that I couldn't be there! I would have loved to see your presentation."
"You've been gone for the last two weeks for your training camp – not much you could have done about that."
"Yeah, but that ended yesterday. I'll be back in town tomorrow, so we can hang out then and you can tell me all about it. I promise that I will be there at graduation. You can count on that!"
"Aww, thanks, but you don't need to go out of your way to be there."
"Of course I do! I don't care what else I have planned – practice or not. You're more important. I've been with you since middle school, and you aren't getting rid of me!"
"I would never want to get rid of you – you're too special to me to lose. Anyways, I'll see you tomorrow, I've got to take it all in. It's… a bit of a shock to say the least. I just wanted to tell someone."
"Well, I'm glad you told me – see you tomorrow!"
Right after our conversation, I took a break in the lounge area that was at the end of the hall to collect myself. I finally let the tears come. After everything, I couldn't believe I made it. That, plus the comments that the review committee had about my work – all of it compounded together made me emotional. So emotional, they heard me outside the lounge area crying. Someone even came in to make sure I was okay. Of course, I was perfectly fine. The emotions just got the best of me… I couldn't control them anymore.

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A few weeks later, Noah and I sat in the graduate student study space, where I'd been frantically – and probably needlessly – reviewing my final dissertation, making a series of small, nitpicky edits, before submitting it to the Scholar's Commons section of Nexus, our school's student information system.
"I think this is it; I made the changes that the committee recommended, and I can't think of anything else. Am I finally done?" I asked Noah, concerned I missed something.
"I think that's it. I say go for it," Noah answered. "It's never going to be perfect – even though you want it to be. At some point making these small changes will just de-value it."
I couldn't help but chuckle. "The law of diminishing returns… I guess that makes sense. Very insightful," I said. I logged on to Nexus, navigated to the Scholar's Commons, and entered my profile. On the page, there was a red link that said, "Dissertation Final Copy Submission." I clicked on it and uploaded the finalized submission of my dissertation. I hovered over the button labelled "Confirm Submission", but I couldn't bring myself to click it, despite how much I wanted to. I don't really know why, but it felt like something was stopping me. "I… I can't do it," I told Noah, shaking with fear.
"Why not? It's just a button," he answered.
"It's not *just a button* – it means so much more. Once I click this button, my academic journey – at least as a student – is over. I want that, so much, but I also don't at the same time. I don't think I'm ready. I don't think I'll ever be ready."
"Dude, you're ready – I know you are," Noah started, pausing for a few seconds before asking "Do you want me to do it for you?"
"No. I'll do it. I just need to come to terms with it."
"What about if we do it together? Would that help?" he asked, gently putting his hand on my shoulder to comfort me.
"I… I don't know, but I like the idea. You've been with me through all the work I've put into this – it's almost like it's as much a part of you as it is a part of me."

Noah carefully put his hand over mine, and said "We'll click it on three, ready?" He paused once again, almost looking for my permission. I nodded at him. He started counting, "One… Two… Three!" I clicked the button, and I felt a small amount of pressure from Noah's finger on top of mine. He really meant it when he said we would do it together. That meant the world to me. The page shifted to a loading screen with a revolving circle, below which read "Processing submission, please wait." The wait felt like it was forever. I felt a sense of anxiety I've never felt before. Once I saw the giant green check mark on the screen with "Submission Accepted" written under it, the feeling went away very quickly.

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I immediately went back to Nexus, but this time to my academic summary, almost expecting it to change in the ten seconds it took me to get there.
"I don't think it would change that fast Cam – you just submitted it," Noah said.
"I don't care – I'm checking it anyways. You never—" I started saying before the page cut me off mid-thought. I looked at the first section – titled "Academic Standing" – within which were only four lines of text:

Dissertation Defense: Successful.
Final Dissertation: Received on Scholar's Commons.
Current Standing: Program Complete – All Requirements Satisfied.
Graduation Status: Application Approved – Eligible to Graduate.

"I'm done," I said, instantly bursting into tears, my head sinking in my hands. "I'm finally done," I said, barely able to speak.
"You're done, Cam, you're done," Noah said as he hugged me tightly. He leaned in close, and whispered, "Congratulations, *Dr. Thorpe,*" emphasizing my name. I didn't know why – but I liked it. He held me in place for a few minutes, occasionally rubbing my back, which calmed me down. A few days later, I checked my summary again, and this time, there was only one line on the page:

Current Standing: Degree Granted by Senate.

There were no special effects. There was no sound. Just words on a page. I don't know why I thought there would be something more than that, but for the first time in a *very* long time, I felt completely still, completely stress-free – like a huge weight had been lifted from my shoulders.

Fast forward three months, and I'm next to cross the stage at our usual August convocation. "For the first time in the history of the Waterloo Institute of Technology, for the degree of Doctor of Science in Computer Science, Cameron Thorpe", the voice of the Chancellor beamed through the loudspeakers of the auditorium as I walked to the center of the stage in my deep green doctoral gown with three brilliant off-white velvet panels on the sleeves. The accompanying green eight-sided tam sat on my head, its golden tassel strewn on the right. I'm huge on symbolism. I've researched convocation symbolism so much I felt like I had an entirely different doctorate in that alone. See what I mean about being a huge nerd? Even though I did have two other degrees, I always started all my convocation ceremonies with the tassel on the right so I can shift it as a symbol of starting the next chapter of my life. My academic hood – the same brilliant gold as the tassel on my head, with chevrons matching my gown and the velvet on it – laid draped across my arm, as is tradition for doctoral candidates. I approached my supervisor, and she carefully took the hood from my arm and unfolded it. I knelt and removed my tam. She gingerly placed the hood over my head and secured it in the back of my gown. I rose, turned to her, and shook her hand. "Thank you for believing in me – even when I didn't believe in myself. I couldn't have done this without you," I whispered to her as I embraced her almost as tightly as Noah did as he comforted me.

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“Along with his degree, Dr. Thorpe leaves convocation with not only the Governor General's gold medal for academic excellence, but also an offer for a tenure-track professorship at WIT. Please join me in offering our most sincere congratulations as he begins this new chapter!” said the Chancellor, her voice still beaming from the speakers. The crowd erupted with applause. As I continued to cross the stage, I locked eyes with Noah, standing in the front row, furiously clapping, and cheering for me at the top of his lungs. I gave him a wink, signaling to him that I saw him, but to me, it meant much more than that. More than he could ever imagine. Much, *much* more.

We’re polar opposites, but for some reason we were inseparable like the two parts of a soap molecule. Noah was always one of the most popular people in school, so why he’s stayed my friend for so long still escapes me. He’s the stereotypical jock: average height – in fact, he’s a few inches shorter than me, extremely fit, with luscious medium-length golden blonde hair – and don’t even get me started on those perfect deep blue eyes, as blue as the nighttime summer sky. I just could stare into them for hours, ignoring the rest of the world as if it didn’t exist. He loves being around people, and they often loved being around him too. I was no different in that regard – I love being around him. To put it in science terms, he’s the polar hydrophilic, water-loving head of the soap molecule. Then, there’s me, the stereotypical nerd. I’m the chubby guy with light, pasty skin, rough black hair and glasses covering my brown eyes that seem to have lost their spark. I’m the guy nobody wanted to hang out with unless they needed homework help. Well, more like they wanted me to do their homework for them. I’m the non-polar lipophilic, fat-loving tail of the soap molecule. Opposite in polarity, sure, but somehow, we worked together perfectly – bound by something invisible yet… unbreakable. Our friendship just… worked.

I first met him in sixth grade when his family moved to Canada from the states. I was his first-ever friend, since I knew what it was like to be an anomaly, an outlier – not fitting in with anyone. Of course, he eventually found his place at the top of the food chain, but he never left my side. He brought me with him, weather I wanted to go or not. He and his family moved here so he could enroll with me, pursuing a degree in communications. How he managed to spend the last ten years studying for the same degree, I'll never know. I would have gone crazy by now if I was still going for my undergrad. He’s only been doing one course every term for the last few years to keep up with the demand of being the captain of the hockey team. I tutored him through many of his science and math requirements since he wasn't the type to enjoy the sciences as I was. He also had to repeat a few courses while he was still doing a full course load because he always put more effort into hockey than he did schoolwork. I’ve often joked with him that if he put as much effort into his schoolwork as he did hockey, he’d have been done his degree when I finished my first one, but he always resisted any sort of academic work. I’ve been there for him through it all though, and he was there for me through all my work too.

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If it’s not clear by now, I love him – more than anything, and I constantly dreamed that I had him all to myself. I’ve had feelings for him for quite a while now, but I thought that given my complete avoidance of the gym – or anything physical for that matter – there’s no way he’d ever feel the same way about me. He knew I didn’t care about anything athletics related, and for the most part, he made sure to avoid the topic while he was with me. We’ve never really talked about it; being more than friends. I never dared to cross that line out of the fear that it might ruin our long friendship. I always assumed he was straight as a board because of his infatuation with all things athletic, but some part of me has always hoped for him to one day come up to me and just confess that he’s gay too and that he’s fallen for me. *Like that would ever happen*, but one can hope.

After I reached my seat and the rest of the graduates crossed the stage, I heard the words that everyone in attendance was waiting for: "In accordance with the laws of the Province of Ontario, by virtue of the power vested in me as Chancellor, and on the recommendation of the Senate of the Waterloo Institute of Technology, I hereby confer upon all candidates the degrees, diplomas and certificates for which they have duly qualified. Congratulations to all of you!” While everyone around me was jumping up and down, throwing their mortarboards in the air and clapping their hands, I casually shifted my tassel to the left side. I was never one for celebrations, but it felt so surreal, all the time and effort I'd spent over the last ten years to study for my undergraduate and graduate degrees and to conduct and defend my research – to now be done, it felt… I don’t know how to describe it, other than *different*.

The speeches went on for what seemed like forever, as they always do, and now it was my turn. As the one who had the highest grade of all graduate students, I had to make one. I have never been someone to speak publicly. Even putting me in a group of people to do coursework was something I couldn't stand. Whenever I saw the words “group project” in a course syllabus, I’d always try to get out of having to do it in a group. It often worked, but there were the odd few times when it didn’t. In those cases, I was always the quietest person in the group, only answering in one or two sentences, and only when absolutely necessary. But for some reason, put me in front of a lecture theatre with a textbook, a syllabus and a PowerPoint presentation – and I could talk forever. It was a completely different side to me that I never thought I had. It was always my dream to lead a classroom, and dare I say, I’m pretty good at it. But, as soon as I walk out of the lecture hall, I return to my usual quiet, borderline antisocial self.

I stepped up to the podium, the assembly of graduates, family, friends, and faculty waiting patiently for me to start speaking. I instantly felt a wave of nervousness like I've never felt before, coupled with the same sense of anxiety I felt when submitting my final dissertation. I cleared my throat – which didn’t help, but I powered through the feelings, and began:

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Fellow graduates, esteemed faculty, beloved family and friends, thank you all for joining us for this special day of celebration. First, to the graduating class, congratulations, we did it! The endless hours spent on course work or research, the late nights preparing for tests or exams, the seemingly endless struggle to get our lab experiments to work out as we want, the weeks of effortlessly trying to solve that one problem on that one assignment that we just couldn't solve – all of it has got us to this moment. The moment every one of us has had in our minds since we started here. The moment where we cross this stage in front of our friends, family and faculty, all of whom have been there for us when we needed them most – in so many ways. Some have provided financial assistance, others emotional assistance, relationship advice, or career advice. All of it has helped us to get to this moment.

To our faculty, family and friends, no matter how small a contribution you've made to our journey here: I speak for all of us when I say thank you. We could not have made it this far without your love, help and support – whether we have acknowledged it in the past or not.

Through my time here at WIT, I've been in many positions – student and faculty – from when I started my undergraduate work, through to my master's, and now my doctorate – I've learned so much – It's safe to say we all have. We are all leaving WIT as completely different people than we were when we started. We've gained new friendships, new relationships, new colleagues, new experiences, and in my opinion, most importantly, new knowledge. The friendships we've made here will last us a lifetime. The relationships we've built here will have a lasting effect on our lives. The knowledge we've gained here will be the basis on which our careers are formed. Whether we know it or not, WIT has shaped us all into the professionals – and people – we are today.

I wish to give special thanks to two people who have helped me get through the many hours of coursework, the seemingly endless number of assignments, and the many, many months and years I've spent in both computer labs writing and debugging code and in traditional labs theorizing, creating experiments, testing hypotheses, and analyzing data. First, if not most obviously, to my supervisor, Dr. Emelia Browne,

I paused, turned to her, and gave her the traditional hat-tip as a sign of my endearing respect for her and for what she's done for me. She reciprocated it by doing the same – which I wasn't expecting – almost to say that I've affected her life in the same way which she's affected mine.

I would like to thank you for all the advice you've given me – not only for my thesis, but for my personal life as well, and for the support you've given me over the years. Moving out of my parents' house right out of high school and moving across the country from

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British Columbia to Ontario left me without anyone to look up to for advice. You were there for me when I needed it most. You were there for me when I didn't know what to do with myself. You were there for me when my experiments failed so much that I felt like just blowing up the lab so I wouldn't have to deal with the failure anymore – figuratively, of course. You helped me through some of the roughest places I've been physically, mentally and emotionally. For all this advice, love and support, I will be forever grateful.

I would also like to now acknowledge someone without whom, in all honesty, I probably wouldn't have had the courage to pursue my graduate studies. I would like to ask Noah Harper to please rise in his seat for this portion of my speech.

I stared out into the audience, where I saw Noah rise in his place, his face filled with surprise. I hadn't told him I put him into my speech, and the version I rehearsed with him didn't include that part. I rehearsed that separately precisely so I could see his genuine reaction. He appeared to be ready to burst into tears by the gesture I just made for him – which was something I didn't think of, but seeing it brought a small smile to my face. *Did I mean as much to him as he did to me?* I thought. *There's no way. There can't be, right?*

Noah, without you, I would never have had the courage to pursue my graduate studies. I would not have been able to complete them either. Even though you're in a completely different discipline as I am, the help you were able to give me while studying for my coursework and candidacy exams, the hours you spent outside of your practice and game schedule just to be with me in the lab so I wouldn't be alone – because let's face it, if I were alone, I would have driven myself insane – means more to me than you could ever know. The years of friendship you've given me have been some of the best of my life. You've been with me through my best days and my worst days. You've seen me excel at my work, and you've seen me on the verge of a mental breakdown, pulling my hair out and getting ready to quit everything. Please, if you will, join me on the stage.

Noah started running at his top speed over to the stairway leading to the stage. On his way up, a staff member gave him a mortarboard, as I requested. He put it on, and he met me at the podium.

For everything you've done for me, I give you my most sincere gratitude.

I paused again so I could tip my hat to him. He took off his and took a bow, almost to infuriate me, but to the audience's amusement. He put it back on his head and tipped it in my direction. I hugged him so tightly that I thought I might pop him, while I whispered "thank you so much for everything" into his ear. He whispered back, "It's my pleasure." I wanted to kiss him so much at that moment – I leaned closer to him to go for it, but for some reason, I stopped myself before I

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did it. As he left the stage, almost in tears – just as I was – I could only think of him: *I love you, Noah Harper. I love you so much. You have no idea how much I want you,* I thought.

> *I will end my time by wishing all of you the best of luck in your future endeavors – graduate studies, research, careers, or even just to figure out what you want to do next. Congratulations to all of us – we've earned it!*

The audience erupted with applause and booming cheers, almost like I said something profound. Who knows, maybe I did. I hoped that my speech resonated with at least one of the hundreds of graduates attending the ceremony. A few more speeches were made, and eventually all the members of my graduating class followed the faculty in the recessional march to the usual sound of bag pipes and drummers, ending one chapter of my life while simultaneously starting another. Now all I needed to worry about is getting through the dinner party I had planned for the night. Wonderful. *Just freaking wonderful.*

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